

OP14 Stretch Assignment Tracking

Pillar	Opportunity	Difficulty	Level 1
Time Required	30-40 minutes (setup), then 5 minutes per assignment	Group Size	Manager solo or 1:1
Mode	Manager self-work and 1:1 check-ins	Format	Any
Prerequisites	OP1 (Ambition Roadmap) and OP2 (Opportunity Mapping) to identify assignment targets	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Limited access to stretch assignments, career growth stalling, high-visibility projects going to same people, development opportunities concentrated in a few team members

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Stretch assignments sit in the neurological sweet spot between comfort and panic. The brain's optimal learning zone (Vygotsky's 'zone of proximal development') is where a task is challenging enough to activate dopamine-driven engagement but not so overwhelming that cortisol shuts down the prefrontal cortex. Stretch assignments that are well-calibrated produce flow states: deep engagement, time distortion, and peak performance.

Tracking stretch assignment distribution prevents a common equity failure: the same high-visibility people receiving every stretch opportunity while others stagnate. The brain's fairness circuits (anterior insula) process this inequity as painful, even for people who don't consciously recognise the pattern.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Assignment Map (15 minutes)

The manager creates a stretch assignment tracking grid:

Person	Last Stretch	Type	Growth Area	Next Opportunity	Timeline
[Name]	[When]	[Project/Role/Exposure]	[From OP1]	[Specific]	[Target date]

The "Last Stretch" column immediately reveals distribution patterns. If one person's last stretch was 6 months ago and another's was last week, the inequity is visible.

Phase 2: Calibrating the Stretch (10 minutes)

For each planned stretch assignment, calibrate using the challenge-skill balance:

CALIBRATION GUIDE

Too easy: the person could do this in their sleep. No growth, no engagement. (Comfort zone.)

Right stretch: the person has 60-70% of the skills needed. They'll need to learn, adapt, and push themselves, but success is achievable with support. (Learning zone.)

Too far: the person has less than 40% of the skills needed. Risk of failure is high, support requirements are extreme, and the cortisol load may be counterproductive. (Panic zone.)

The sweet spot: they're nervous but excited, not terrified.

Phase 3: Support Design (5 minutes per assignment)

Each stretch assignment needs a support plan:

- Who's the safety net? (someone they can go to when they're stuck, without judgment)
- What check-in cadence? (more frequent for bigger stretches, lighter for smaller ones)
- What does 'good enough' look like? (stretch assignments should not be held to the same standard as work in someone's area of expertise)
- What's the debrief plan? (after the assignment, structured reflection on what was learned)

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
The tracking grid reveals that one person has had no stretch opportunity in over 6 months	Address it immediately in the next 1:1: "I've been reviewing how I distribute growth opportunities and I owe you a better stretch assignment. Let's look at what's coming up and find the right one." Then follow through.
A stretch assignment overwhelms the person (panic zone, not learning zone)	Recalibrate, don't remove. "This might have been a bigger stretch than we planned. Let's adjust the scope or add support rather than pulling you off it entirely." Pulling someone off a stretch assignment can be more damaging than the difficulty itself.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
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OP1: Ambition Roadmap	OP1 identifies growth directions. OP14 provides the specific stretch experiences that move people along their roadmap.	OP1 feeds into OP14
OP2: Opportunity Mapping	OP2 identifies available stretch opportunities. OP14 allocates and tracks them.	OP2 feeds into OP14
L10: Equitable Learning	OP14's tracking grid serves the same equity function as L10's access audit, applied to stretch assignments.	Complementary
V7: Reducing Fear of Failure	Stretch assignments require safe-to-fail conditions. V7 establishes them.	V7 supports OP14